

“He Sat to Watch o’er Customs Paid”

Text: William Bright, 1889

Meter: 8.8.8.8

Suggested Tune: ALFRETON

1. He sat to watch o’er customs paid,
a man of scorned and hardening trade;
alike the symbol and the tool
of foreign masters hated rule.
2. But grace within his breast had stirred;
there needed but the timely word;
it came, true Lord of souls, from Thee,
that royal summons, “Follow me.”
3. Enough, when Thou wert passing by,
to hear Thy voice, to meet Thine eye:
he rose, responsive to the call,
and left his task, his gains, his all.
4. O wise exchange with these to part,
and lay up treasure in Thy heart;
with twofold crown of light to shine
amid Thy servants’ foremost line.
5. Come, savior, as in days of old;
pass where the world has strongest hold,
and faithless care and selfish greed
are thorns that choke the holy seed.
6. Who keep Thy gifts, O bid them claim
the steward’s, not the owner’s name;
who yield all up for Thy dear sake,
let them of Matthew’s wealth partake.

Reflection (Feast of St. Matthew):

This text begins with the story of his conversion as described in Matthew 9:9. Matthew is doing his job, collecting taxes. The people of his day resented tax collectors. As a tax collector, Matthew would have been the representative (“the

symbol and the tool”) of Roman jurisdiction in Israel.

But, as Matthew recounts in his own gospel, Christ merely had to pass by the tax collector booth and tell him “Follow me” for Matthew to drop all that he was doing and follow Him. This is the working of grace, the free gift from God, which had been planted as a seed within Matthew’s heart and needed only a simple beckon to grow into his complete conversion. The hymn text poetically describes this moment of conversion in vv. 2-3.

Verse 4 commends Matthew on multiple accounts. First of all, for his wise discernment in exchanging his sinful, thieving profession as a tax collector to now serve Christ. And second of all, for being one of the only two apostles (the other being John) to hold the titles of both Apostle and Evangelist. This is the “twofold crown” that he wears now in heaven.

The hymn concludes with a petition for God to pass by us, just like he did with Matthew, to call us into service. Then, the seeds that have been planted in our hearts will also grow, rather than being choked by the worldly thorns described in the Parable of the Sower (Mat. 13:22). Once we have done this, then we will partake of the same wealth that Matthew now claims – not earthly money acquired as a tax collector, but the heavenly treasures of the Beatific Vision.